

Lactation consultants make a big difference for first-time mothers

Taupō mum Lucy Harrison shares her story and breastfeeding journey for World Breastfeeding Week, 1-7 August.



Lucy Harrison with her son, George. Photo: She By Shan

As a first-time mum, and nearly six years after gastric bypass surgery, Lucy knew breastfeeding might be a struggle.

Her son George was born by caesarean section earlier than planned, throwing a curveball at her plans and meaning she went into the birth feeling unprepared and unorganised.

"I had no idea what to expect or what was going to happen with my milk supply when my son was born," Lucy says.

Lucy's premature baby needed to gain weight, so she had to breastfeed, provide formula top-ups and express milk to increase her supply.

"It was a very intense couple of days. By 48 hours after birth, I was overwhelmed, sleep-deprived, in pain and recovering from a caesarean.

"There were a couple of times when I just cried and wanted to give up because I didn't think I could do it. I found it overwhelming and difficult to focus and learn while so tired and following this intensive feeding programme."

After three days at Rotorua Hospital, Lucy transferred to the Taupō Maternity Unit, where she was introduced to the lactation consultants.

"I received the most outstanding, consistent support from my midwife, Suzanne Buxton, as well as advice and support from lactation consultants Chelsea Robertson and Kristina McConaghie.

"I spent two days there and went home feeling much more prepared and motivated that I could potentially do it. I just needed to give it time."

Being able to see her milk production increase, and how much she could express, gave Lucy reassurance and confidence that George was receiving what he needed.

Lucy was still struggling with nipple pain and latching but wanted to keep going for her son. She was determined to give it a few more weeks to see whether it would ease.

Her midwife suggested further help from the lactation consultants. Kristina visited Lucy at home, shared tips for different feeding styles and reminded her to use the BreastFedNZ app.

"The app has been an amazing guide, filled with information and different breastfeeding techniques and positions that I can refer back to when I'm struggling or need to know something."

"I am so proud of myself for pushing through the days when I wanted to give up. I couldn't have done it without the care and support I received from the midwives and lactation consultants, who continued to listen, support and be so kind and helpful."

Lucy's advice to other mothers who are struggling is to give the new journey a chance, take a breath and not be afraid to ask for help and support within their community.

"I think breastfeeding is one of the most difficult but rewarding things you can do as a woman. There are so many amazing resources and sources of support in the community. You are not a failure for asking for extra support."

Contact the regional lactation consultants

Email: Lakes.baby@lakesdhb.govt.nz

Phone: 0800 Lakes Baby (0800 525 372)